



The History of LEGO

Comprehension Questions

1. What was Ole Kirk Kristiansen's original business?

2. Name two of the original wooden toys produced by the LEGO factory. Why did the factory begin to manufacture toys?

3. Which purchase revolutionised the way toys were made in the factory?

4. Choose one of the subheadings in the text. Why did the author choose this and why is it effective?

5. How did Kristiansen settle on the name LEGO? Give two facts from the text.

6. What was the philosophy behind the LEGO system of play? Why did Godtfred Kirk Kristiansen develop it?

7. Give two facts the author gives us about the patent for LEGO bricks.



8. How tall are standard minifigures? How did they make Yoda even shorter?

9. How many LEGO blocks are produced each minute?

10. Find two words from the box 'Awesome Combinations' that show the author is impressed by the numbers of brick combinations.

Extension

- One pupil wrote, 'The author of the article seems to clearly appreciate the work ethic and business success of the LEGO company.' To what extent do you agree with this assessment?
- Research one of the world records held for LEGO building. What happened, when and why? Why do you think there is an enduring fascination with LEGO?
- Based on the article you've read, what do you think is the secret of LEGO's enduring success? What advice might you take from this to give a start-up company?



The History of LEGO

Comprehension - Answers

1. What was Ole Kirk Kristiansen's original business?

Ole Kirk Kristiansen was a woodworker/carpenter and his original business was a workshop specialising in furniture and house supplies.

2. Name two of the original wooden toys produced by the LEGO factory. Why did the factory begin to manufacture toys?

The workshop made pull-along toys, building blocks and yo-yos. The factory began to manufacture toys because the world-wide depression of the 1930s had caused huge drops in housing and furniture sales.

3. Which purchase revolutionised the way toys were made in the factory?

In 1947 Kristiansen bought a plastic-injection moulding machine which allowed greater detail and started producing the blocks that would become LEGO.

4. Choose one of the subheadings in the text. Why did the author choose this and why is it effective?

Answers will vary based on the subheading chosen.

5. How did Kristiansen settle on the name LEGO? Give two facts from the text.

The text states that there was a competition to choose a name. The prize was a bottle of wine but Kristiansen himself won the competition since he chose his own name - LEGO - made from the combination of Danish words Leg and Godt, meaning 'play well'. The word is also a Latin verb meaning 'to assemble' or 'put together'.

6. What was the philosophy behind the LEGO system of play? Why did Godtfred Kirk Kristiansen develop it?

Godtfred Kirk Kristiansen developed the system of play in which every element could connect to every other element. He wanted to create 'a toy that prepares the child for life, appeals to the imagination, and develops the creative urge and joy of creation that are the driving force in every human being.'

7. Give two facts the author gives us about the patent for LEGO bricks.

The author mentions the development of the new brick in 1957 and the patent of it in 1958. The patent is now used in over 33 countries. The two by four stud brick is still made in the same way.

8. How tall are standard minifigures? How did they make Yoda even shorter?

1½ inches tall. Yoda was made smaller by making shorter legs.

9. How many LEGO blocks are produced each minute?

36,000 are produced every minute.

10. Find two words from the box 'Awesome Combinations' that show the author is impressed by the numbers of brick combinations.

Choices are 'awesome', 'staggering', 'remarkable' and 'astounding'.

Extension

- One pupil wrote, 'The author of the article seems to clearly appreciate the work ethic and business success of the LEGO company.' To what extent do you agree with this assessment?

Answers will vary. Credit students for explanation and supporting evidence.

- Research one of the world records held for LEGO building. What happened, when and why? Why do you think there is an enduring fascination with LEGO?

Thousands of LEGO related records can be found on the Guinness World Records site: <http://guinnessworldrecords.com>. Search under LEGO.

- Based on the article you've read, what do you think is the secret of LEGO's enduring success? What advice might you take from this to give a start-up company?

Students might create a booklet or poster as a guide for success to small businesses. They might mention the tenacity of the company; even when facing closure the founder considered making other products and began to produce toys. They might also mention making investment in the future (the plastic injection-moulding machine purchase) and believing that only the best will do.